ethos. ‘My government is here for you,’ he claimed. The audience, though, was dominated by wealthy property developers, restaurant owners and car dealers. The average Muslim, it seems, still saw Modi through the prism of 2002. He would clearly need to do much more than well-crafted photo ops to win their trust.

Modi, though, wasn’t too concerned that his pitch to the Muslim community had made only a limited headway. With small and large parties by his side, he was now heading a robust twenty-party-plus NDA alliance. The Congress, by contrast, was in danger of either gaining no new friends, or, in some instances, losing even its sitting MPs.

Jagdambika Pal, its senior UP MP and spokesperson, quit on the eve of the elections. The off-record reason he gave some journalists on the Congress beat for switching sides reflected poorly on the party. Apparently, he had been seeking an appointment with Rahul for weeks. ‘Every time I tried, some operator in his office would keep me waiting on the phone. I finally got tired of waiting!’ he claimed. He, like many Congress MPs, did not have direct access to Rahul nor his mobile number. But the truth is, Jagdambika, like so many others, just wanted to be on the winning side. The saying in UP, after all, is *‘Ugta suraj ko sab namaksar karte hain’* (All salute the rising sun).

The only new ally the Congress got was Lalu Prasad in Bihar, and even that was not without controversy. Rahul did not like Lalu. The RJD leader, he felt, represented an old-style politics of caste and corruption that discomfited him. When he had spoken out against the ordinance that provided a reprieve to convicted MPs, it was leaders like Lalu who had been Rahul’s target. In the 2009 Lok Sabha and 2012 assembly elections in Bihar, Rahul had resisted a Congress–RJD tie-up. This time, too, he kept Lalu waiting.

Meeting Lalu at his Delhi residence as he waited for a nod from the Congress, I could sense his growing frustration. I said I wanted to interview him. *‘Arre, interview toh theek hai, par pehle bolne ko kuch hona chahiye’* (I can do an interview, but at least I should have something to say). I asked him what the problem was. *‘Arre, hamein kyon poochte ho, Rahul Gandhiji*